

Simple Shapes Method

Breaking down complexity into geometric primitives

The simple shapes method is a way of seeing — stripping away detail and surface information to find the underlying geometric structure. It is one of the fastest routes from 'can't draw' to 'can draw anything'.

KEY CONCEPTS

Squinting

Squint at your reference. This blurs detail and reveals the main shapes. What big shape is this? A rectangle? An oval? An irregular blob? Draw that shape first. Get its proportions right before adding detail.

Shape Hierarchy

Draw from large to small. The whole head before the eye; the whole torso before the muscles; the whole hand before the fingers. Each level of detail should fit within the larger shape you established first.

Bounding Boxes

For complex subjects, start with a bounding box — the simplest rectangle that contains the whole subject. Then subdivide this box to find where major elements sit relative to the whole.

When to Stop Simplifying

Simplify until you've captured the essential gesture and proportion. Then add one level of detail at a time. The test: would someone recognize the subject from the simple shape stage? If yes, move on.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw 10 animals using only circles, ovals, and rectangles. No detail.
2. Take a complex portrait reference and draw only the major shape of the head and features.
3. Draw a cityscape as bounding rectangles only — no windows, no doors.

FURTHER READING

■ Proko – Simple Shapes

<https://youtu.be/H9e9P9HJmLs>

■ Ctrl+Paint – Shape Design